opened at the other and Jadeja replaced Sharma after only two overs. By the middle of the 13th over, the two spinners had reduced us to a humiliating 12 runs for five wickets. The pitch was almost unplayable, but JP Duminy fought well and made 35. We were finally bowled out for 79 in our first innings and for 185 in our second innings, and defeated within three days for the second time in the series.

The pattern continued in the fourth Test at Delhi. India won the toss for the fourth time in four Tests, opted to bat and made 334 in their first innings, with Ajinkya Rahane becoming the first player on either side to score a century in the series. We were then bowled out for 121 and, once Ajinkya had scored his second century of the match, were set an impossible target of 481 to win. The series was already lost but, as we started our second innings just after lunch on the fourth day, we wanted to show some guts and put up a fight.

Hashim and I came together at 49 for two and batted till stumps and well into the last day, fighting and blocking, making them earn every wicket. Hash scored 25 in almost five hours, and I made 43 in almost six hours. Faf then made 10 runs in two hours as we battled to salvage a draw that would have felt like a consolation victory, but it was not to be and we lost our last five wickets in the final session.

The Indians had played well and played to their strengths, and our bowlers had fought manfully. In the end, we had not scored enough runs to be competitive. Our victories in the T20 and ODI series seemed lost in the dark and distant past by the time we flew home to play a series against a confident England team.

We were starting to look like – to use a dreaded cliché – a team in transition, struggling for confidence, relying too much on too few players and missing the firepower of the injured Dale Steyn.

Maybe a dip in our form was inevitable. No team in the world could afford to lose players and characters as important as Boucher, Kallis and Smith in the space of a few years and not suffer a very significant impact.